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A NOTE ON *SERVIVISTI* (PETR. 57.4)

The uniqueness of the form *servivisti* (Petr. 57.4) has gone almost entirely unremarked: it is the sole uncontracted *-vis*-perfect form in the entire *Satyricon* (including 2 sg. pl. perf. *-visti/-vistis*, perf. act. infin. *-visse*, and plupf. subj. *-vissem, -visses*, etc.), as against nearly 60 forms of the type *pugnasti* (9.10),[1] *turbastis* (16.3),[2] *improbasse* (4.5),[3] and *parasset* (9.2),[4] distributed among almost all of the characters in the work.[5] As such, *servivisti* is either a normative lapse on the part of a copyist (and should be summarily emended to *servisti*), or else it is a telling bit of Petronian stylistic variation.

The remarkably consistent nature of the manuscript tradition with respect to this feature speaks strongly against taking *servivisti* as a copying lapse. Rather, the interpretation of the form follows naturally from the well known status of variants like *servisti* vs. *servivisti*. Manu Leumann, in his excellent survey of shortened *v*-perfect forms, observes: "Die Kurzformen gehören seit Plautus der Umgangssprache an; vgl. Cic. *Orat.* 157 zu *nosse iudicasse* und Quint. 1.6.17 u. 21 zu pedantischem *scivisse audivisse* und *conservavisse*."[6] The

[1]Also *laudasti* 10.2, *numerasti* 58.2, *involasti* 58.10, *excatarissasti* 67.10, *nosti* 75.7, 126.1, *violasti* 79.11, *petisti* 97.9, *calcasti* 134.1, *vindicasti/excitasti* 134.2.

[2]Also *cenastis* 74.6.

[3]Also *cenasse* 41.5, *intrasse* 47.9, 101.7, 136.13, *habitasse* 77.1, *praecipitasse* 102.9, *expirasse* 112.3, *peccasse* 130.1, 130.4; here also the partially shortened *dormiisse* 104.2.

[4]Also *monstrasset* 18.3, *intrassemus* 31.1, *intrasset* 41.1, 74.8, *vindicasset* 41.4, *sufflasses* 45.11, *adiutasses* 62.11, *gustasset* 66.5, *putasses* 77.1, *pernoctassemus* 79.6, *imperasset* 83.5, *obdormissem* 86.2, *iactasset* 87.4, *audisset* 105.9, 11.6, *durassent* 105.11, *maculassent* 106.1, *notasset* 111.6, *temptasset* 117.10, *provocassem* 137.6, *lustrasset* 137.10, *donasset* 138.6, *lassasset/perseverasset* 139.3, *praeparassem* 139.5, *servasset* 140.6.

[5]To my knowledge, the only notice of this feature appears in a brief discussion of "Kontrahierte und nicht kontrahierte Formen des Perfektstammes," in Gerhard Bendz' "Sprachliche Bemerkungen zu Petron," *Eranos* 39 (1941) 51–3. Bendz simply lists *servivisti*, as well as *vovisti* 107.15 and *removisse* 125.2, as exceptions to the fact that *v*-perfects are otherwise contracted; his discussion, however, concerns the fact that contracted *r*-forms, as in many authors, are extremely rare (only *optarunt* 61.1, *naufragarunt* 76.4). On *vovisti* and *removisse*, and on perfect forms of *eo* (and its compounds), see n. 6 below.

[6]*Lateinische Laut- und Formenlehre* (Munich 1977) 598–601 (600 on *-ivi* perfects specifically); similarly A. Ernout, *Morphologie historique du latin*[3] (Paris 1953) 211–12.

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passages to which Leumann refers are illuminating for the interpretation of *servivisti*, and deserve to be cited more fully in this connection.

Both passages concern the clash, in ancient grammatical and rhetorical theory, between so-called "anomalists," for whom language behavior should be dictated primarily by actual usage, and "analogists," who urged strict adherence to a canon of regularizing (and analogically based) linguistic rules that often contradicted actual usage, partly by restoring obsolete forms.[7] In a discussion of *analogia*, Quintilian refers (1.6.17) to the "highly affected excess of strictness" (*molestissima diligentiae perversitate*) that led some of its practitioners to say things like *audaciter* instead of *audacter*, or *conire* instead of *coire*, and goes on to remark, rather sarcastically, that "We may as well let them say *audivisse* and *scivisse* and *tribunale* and *faciliter*." Quintilian admits, to be sure, that a standard of correctness is desirable, and that change in the language should be resisted to some extent; but there is a limit: "The retention of obsolete and discarded forms is a mark of affectation, and of needless arrogance with respect to minutiae" (*abolita atque abrogata retinere insolentiae cuiusdam est et frivolae in parvis iactantiae*, 1.6.20). Here again, he goes on to list (1.6.21) some characteristic examples of unnecessarily retained archaic forms, "in contrast to what we actually say" (*potius quam quod dicimus*), and among such forms is the unshortened *v*-perfect *conservavisse*.

Cicero's discussion (*Orat.* 155–62) is similar, except that Cicero reveals a higher degree of linguistic sophistication, not only in his recognition of synchronic variation, but in his suggestion that it can even be exploited on occasion. In a lengthy and thoroughly documented treatment of the masculine genitive plural variation *-orum*

See also the extensive documentation in Friedrich Neue, *Formenlehre der lateinischen Sprache* (Dritte Auflage von C. Wagener) (Berlin 1897) 3.430–78. Note, incidentally, that *vovisti* (107.15) and *removisse* (125.2)—the only other uncontracted *-vis*-forms in Petronius apart from *servivisti*—are not to be considered irregularly uncontracted, like *servivisti*, given the contraction behavior expected for *-ovi* perfects: contraction is frequent for forms of *novi*, but rare (though well documented) for forms of *movi*, and almost never found for forms of *vovi*; see Leumann 599 and Neue-Wagener 3.492. (Similarly already Bendz [n. 5 above] 52, n. 1.) The variation found with perfect forms of *eo* (and its compounds) is of a more complex nature, and is left out of account in the present discussion; see Leumann, 600 for details.

[7]See in general Eduard Norden, *Die antike Kunstprosa* (Leipzig 1898) 1.184–94.

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vs. *-um*, Cicero concludes (156) that he knows perfectly well what is "correct," but in a given situation feels free to make use of the possibilities for variation inherent in the language (*quid verum sit intellego; sed alias ita loquor ut concessum est*). He continues with a further example (157): 'And what about speaking like this: they forbid saying *nosse* and *iudicasse*, and insist that we say *novisse* and *iudicavisse*—as if we really didn't know that in this case the full form is the "correct" one, and the shortened form the one we actually use' (*Quid quod sic loqui: "nosse, iudicasse" vetant, "novisse" iubent et "iudicavisse"? Quasi vero nesciamus in hoc genere et plenum verbum recte dici et imminutum usitate*). No wonder, then, that Cicero almost never wrote *-ivisti*, generally preferring the shortened form *-isti*, including the very form *servisti* itself.[8]

In view of the above, it seems surprising, to say the least, that in Petronius, the unique uncontracted form *servivisti* is uttered by a freedman.[9] But consider the context. The speaker is delivering a tirade against Ascyltos, and particularly against his elitist attitude and behavior. The silly party favors described in 56.8–9, featuring Trimalchio's inimitable brand of inane punning "humor," had just elicited general laughter (*Diu risimus: sexcenta huiusmodi fuerunt, quae iam exciderunt memoriae meae*, 56.10). But Ascyltos' excessive reaction is singled out, and leads directly to the freedman's tirade: *Ceterum Ascyltos, intemperantis licentiae, cum omnia sublatis manibus eluderet et usque ad lacrimas rideret, unus ex conlibertis Trimalchionis excanduit* (57.1). After

[8]*Fam.* 16.18.1, in a letter to Tiro: *indulge valetudini tuae; cui quidem tu adhuc, dum mihi deservis, servisti non satis.* For a sense of the rarity of *-ivisti*, see Neue-Wagener (n. 6 above) 3.435, where only six *-ivisti* forms are listed (three each in Plautus and Cicero), as against approximately 150 citations for *-isti* (with similar ratios for *-ivistis* vs. *-istis*, *-ivisse* vs. *-isse*, *-ivissem* vs. *-issem*, etc.). Indeed, one of the cited Plautine *-ivisti* forms (*audivisti, Stich.* 246) is to be scanned *audisti*. It can also be shown that some of the other rare instances of uncontracted forms are used expressly for their formal ring. This may be the case, for example, with Cicero's *impedivisti* (*Att.* 13.47a.1), which appears in an otherwise extremely informal letter to Atticus. Inviting Atticus and Pilia to dinner, Cicero writes: *Tu velim, nisi te impedivisti, apud nos prid. Kal. cum Pilia*, 'Come on over to my place with Pilia—unless you are otherwise engaged' (lit. 'unless you have "encumbered yourself"'), where the formal parenthesis produces a mildly jocular effect. I hope to treat elsewhere the pedagogical implications of the fact that we routinely teach our beginning students forms like *audivisti* (and similarly *audivistis, audivisse, audivissem* etc.), which are in fact largely unattested.

[9]He is conventionally identified as Hermeros; see, e.g., Martin S. Smith, *Petronii Arbitri Cena Trimalchionis* (Oxford 1975) 154, ad 57.1.

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directing some abusive questions and comments at Ascyltos, the freedman continues (57.4): *Eques Romanus es: et ego regis filius. "Quare ergo servivisti?"* That is, the freedman's lofty (and rather odd) claim *ego regis filius*—which, predictably, has been variously interpreted by modern scholars—naturally invites the question "*Quare ergo servivisti?*," which the freedman mouths as if asked by Ascyltos. Thus the stilted and pedantic form *servivisti* is used pointedly: it is a barb against Ascyltos' affected style. It matters not that Ascyltos has in fact said *pugnasti* (9.10) and *laudasti* (10.2) earlier in the novel, and so would probably not use a form like *servivisti* in casual conversation. The freedman, in fulminating against Ascyltos' mannered behavior, naturally puts an affected form in his mouth—a type of form, indeed, that was not only affected already for Cicero, but which had a certain prominence in Roman grammatical theorizing.[10]

In context, then, the appropriateness and effectiveness of the form *servivisti* give us no cause to suspect the text, despite the apparent anomaly. Instead, this deceptively ordinary form (which deviates from the classical norm every bit as effectively, in its way, as the freedmen's numerous solecisms) provides new insight into Petronius' extraordinary linguistic—and especially sociolinguistic—sensitivity and artistry.

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[10]The same speaker's subsequent tirade against Giton, which contains two instances of contracted 2 sg. *v*-perfect forms (*numerasti* 58.2, *involasti* 58.10), subtly reinforces the point.

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